



Cover story **Mumbai Attacks**

Lessons from MUMBAI

Intelligence failure, ill-equipped forces, lack of coordination and apathy. Everything that could go wrong went wrong in Mumbai.

| By Malini Bhupta, Aditi Pai and Swati Mathur in Mumbai |

At 6.30 p.m. on December 3, a week after the terror attacks, two bags containing 8 kg of potentially explosive RDX were found on platform number 15 at the crowded Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus (CST) in Mumbai. The bag containing RDX was found in rucksacks like the ones used by the terrorists among the luggage of victims stacked in one corner of the terminus. This is a city on the edge and a police force that is supposed to have been alert. You would imagine that following the attack at CST, the police would have mopped the place for any evidence, sniffer dogs must have been deployed and the luggage sanitised. Yet a week later, the explosive was sitting at CST awaiting discovery. It's as if India's worst-ever terrorist attack had not happened.

It is this casualness, the lack of capacity to comprehend and act, that allowed terrorists to plan and execute what is now being called India's 9/11 that claimed 173 lives and left 288 wounded. The basics, who could do what, where, when, why and how that determines the core of counter terrorism strategy, was lost in a maze of politics. Thomas Kean, who headed the National Commission to probe the 9/11 attacks in the US had observed that the attack reflected not just a failure of intelligence but the failure of policy, management, capability and above all a "failure of imagination". He could have been talking about the 26/11 attacks by terrorists across Mumbai. The terrorists chose to come by sea, target the twin towers of the Taj and Oberoi, attacked a crowded rail terminus, planned to blow up an airport and internationalised their cause by targeting foreigners and above all a Jewish outreach centre at Nariman House.

At least six intelligence reports from the Research & Analysis Wing dating from September to as late as November 19 pointed out the possibility of a sea-borne fidayeen attack. The Taj Hotel and the CST station were among the attacks repeatedly referred to. Yet the terrorists had a free run of the coast, landed without trouble and struck at will. Predictably, the state Government claims it got no warnings and the Centre insists it did warn the state. Typically in the Indian tradition, everyone is responsible but nobody is accountable.

A reconstruction of the events reveals that everything that could have gone wrong went wrong. The city has been a sitting duck for such an attack. The coastline, for instance, is patrolled by three agencies—the Navy on the high seas, the Coast Guard and the Marine Patrol. The Navy absolved itself that it patrols the high seas. The Coast Guard took cover under the issue of scale. After all, there are 5,000 trawlers and checking them all is impossible. Also the landing happened in the domain of the coast patrolled by the Marine Police. Under the Marine Fishing Regulation Act (MFRA), enforced since 1993-94, the Centre provides 100 per cent assistance to states on capital costs of patrol boats and communication equipment to be used for patrolling. Yet states have failed to implement the scheme. According to the Comptroller and Auditor General, Maharashtra refused to pick up the tab for maintenance and underutilised the funds. Ergo, the police, believe it or not, has just five boats—of which two are non-functional—to patrol the 760 km of Maharashtra coastline. To get a sense of the callousness that marks governance, consider this: the terrorists could have hit



THE BLOODBATH AT THE CHHATRAPATI SHIVAJI TERMINUS